monk. On another, applicants at the ministry of home affairs (aka Jaisalmer House) are drawn on their knees in front of the reception desk, lining up in parallel counters, eager to "genuflect before a higher power".

"I have a very light and breezy relationship with religion," says Banerjee. "I love the *taur-tareeka*, the rituals. And I move between religions very easily, whether it's Durga Puja or a Catholic ceremony or Shia Islam stuff. When I'm feeling down, I'll go to the Pahari Wala Gurudwara and eat the samosas served there. That's my sense of religiosity—samosas, feeding people, bringing people together. Of course, there's all this darkness around religion and religiosity as well, which I ignore."

Brighu is Banerjee's alter ego, but he is also a fully formed character, complete with well-defined motivations and anxieties, especially sexual insecurity—a theme Banerjee has depicted with wit in *Corridor* and *The Barn-Owl's Wondrous Capers*. In fact, there's a bravura passage in *Absolute Jafar* where Brighu and Mahrukh are struggling to conceive, and this passage ends with a small illustration of a smug, self-satisfied man in a traditional *pugree* (turban). This is an allusion to Hakim Gulabkhus Peshawari, an eccentric quack-sexologist from *Corridor*; his presence on this page draws a straight line between a young man's sexual insecurities and an older, world-weary man hoping for a child.

"As a medium, comics is all about *gaayab* (absent) and *haazir* (present)," says Banerjee. "Comics is a medium of absences. I am giving you an image and a couple of lines of text, and how you are reading those two things in conjunction has to do with your life experiences. Your mind 'fills' the void, the absence. The comic book artist, who does not wish to spell things out, is like a yoga instructor who'll just correct your posture slightly and let you do the stretching yourself." ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

Down Old Paths

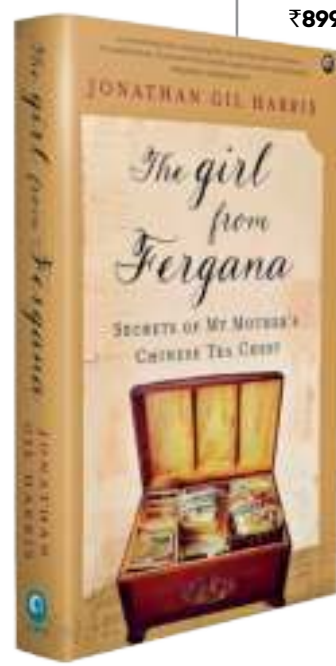
JONATHAN GIL HARRIS'S SPRAWLING FAMILY MEMOIR CONNECTS HIS MOTHER'S LIFE WITH MILLENNIA OF JEWISH HISTORY

If you want to build a big car, says Salman Rushdie, you start with a big engine. What he means to say apropos his novels, usually about violence dripping down family trees like caustic black acid, is that as long as he focuses on the story—character, image, dialogue, rhythm—he can successfully weave a convoluted tapestry of history and politics that does not overwhelm the reader. Jonathan Gil Harris, author of the recent *The Girl from Fergana*, about his Jewish mother's rich and dramatic life, would have written an infinitely more engaging book had he adhered to that rule.

There are passages of pleasing vivacity—the account of how Yiddish is frowned upon by Harris's great-grandmother due to its association with poverty, for example. Or another, describing how his grandmother is wooed by his grandfather with a song that has roots in a Hebrew song about forbidden love, or how his mother sees German planes fly overhead in the days preceding their invasion of Poland. But such intimate scenes lose their potency when scaffolded with encyclopedia-esque prose; a more stylised retelling of history would have sharpened the memoir's focus on this 20th-century life.

HARRIS DESCRIBES HOW HIS GRANDFATHER WOOED HIS GRANDMOTHER USING A SONG WITH ROOTS IN A HEBREW TEXT

THE GIRL FROM FERGANA: Secrets of my Mother's Chinese Tea Chest
By Jonathan Gil Harris
ALEPH
₹899; 344 pages



It's frustrating to read a rigorously researched account—supplemented with exhaustive interviews with a woman who clearly had hair-raising stories to tell—stumble in execution. Harris's mother was born to an interclass marriage, raised in a cosmopolitan household stretching its wings across the vestiges of ancient trade routes, was deported all the way to another part of the globe into hostile labour camps, revisited sites from her past as an adult to relive trauma few people alive today can even begin to comprehend, yet that eventful and affecting biography is lost in a morass of blandly narrated history. Covering a 2,500-year-long sweep of Jewish stories, languages, geographies and mercantilism is no mean task, but this reader was left wondering whether Harris might have done better expanding the volume to give each fact room to breathe. ■

—Udbhav Seth